AI PRACTICALS

THE PRACTICAL AI TOOLKIT

25 Repeatable Workflows for Work and Everyday Life

CLARIFY | CREATE | REVIEW

A practical guide to drafting, research, learning, design, data, automation, and safer AI-assisted work.

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25 Repeatable Workflows for Work and Everyday Life

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PURPOSE AND RESPONSIBILITY

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Tool features, access, prices, limits, privacy terms, and licensing conditions may change. Check the official page for the specific service, plan, account type, and region before depending on it.

Reference date for this edition: 15 October 2026. Confirm current details directly with the linked official sources before relying on them.

Welcome: make AI useful, not complicated

This book is organized around outcomes, not hype. You do not need to understand machine learning to begin. Use the guide to draft a message, understand a document, learn a topic, make a design, prepare a meeting, improve a spreadsheet, or document a repeatable process.

The goal is not to use AI for every task. It is to make the right task faster or clearer without creating new errors, privacy risks, or unnecessary cost. Sometimes a standard search, spreadsheet formula, checklist, or human conversation is the better tool.

How to use this edition

Choose a task from the quick finder. Start with one suitable tool, follow the workflow, customize the prompt, and check the result against the acceptance standard. Save the version that passes so you can reuse it.

What makes this toolkit different

The core unit is a repeatable workflow, not a clever prompt. Each recipe begins with the outcome, names the inputs, gives a sequence to follow, supplies a prompt, and defines a check for deciding whether the result is ready. That structure makes the method portable across tools and easier to improve when a failure repeats.

- **Task-first guidance:** choose a tool because of the job to be done, not because it is popular.
- **Repeatable methods:** the workflows define inputs, steps, prompts, example outcomes, and final checks.
- **Audience playbooks:** students, professionals, freelancers, small businesses, households, and corporate teams each get a practical starting route.
- **Honest limitations:** free access can be restricted, plans can change, and AI output is not proof.
- **Human accountability:** important numbers, sources, commitments, policies, and decisions must be verified.

Contents

Use the links below to jump to a section. This toolkit is designed to work as both a linear read and a task-by-task reference.

1. Start here	The CLEAR method, task finder, and prompt formula.
2. Tool directory	Curated tools, official links, strengths, and caveats.
3. Step-by-step workflows	25 repeatable recipes for everyday, professional, and personal tasks.
4. Worked examples	Six examples with inputs, outputs, and checks.
5. Playbooks by audience	Starter routes for six audiences.
6. Copy-ready prompt library	40 prompts to copy, customize, and verify.
7. Work and corporate use	Governance, approvals, privacy, and pilots.
8. Quality, safety, and troubleshooting	A review rubric, failure fixes, and boundaries.
9. Seven-day implementation plan	A practical rollout and value measurement.
10. Reusable templates	Project briefs, decision memos, checklists, and risk registers.
11. Quick reference glossary	Plain-language definitions for key terms.
12. Official reference desk	Official product, privacy, pricing, and licensing pages.

A reliable habit: define the task, provide safe context, specify the output, test it, and review it before use.

1. Start here: a repeatable AI workflow

The CLEAR method: five moves from request to reliable result

The memorable method in this book is CLEAR: Clarify the outcome, Load the relevant context, Establish constraints and output, Ask for a testable result, and Review before release. Use it as a mental checklist before you open a tool. It works with short prompts, complex documents, and team workflows because it focuses on the quality of the work rather than a particular model.

Step	Do this	A practical example
C - Clarify	State the job and the result that would make the task complete.	"Turn these notes into a list of decisions and actions."
L - Load context	Give the audience, source material, constraints, deadline, and things that must not change.	"The project lead needs a one-page recap. Do not infer owners or dates."
E - Establish the output	Tell the assistant how to return the result and what must not change.	"Use a table with action, owner, due date, evidence, and open question."
A - Ask for a testable result	Require a result that can be checked, with assumptions and gaps made visible.	Compare every action against the original notes.
R - Review before release	Check facts, sources, calculations, privacy, completeness, and next steps.	"Keep all facts; split confirmed decisions from suggestions; flag unknowns."

Quick task finder

I need to...	Start with...	Then verify...
Draft, plan, explain, or rewrite	One general assistant such as ChatGPT, Gemini, or Claude.	Facts, tone, completeness, and assumptions.
Research current information	A web-search assistant plus Google Search or the relevant official site.	That each citation opens and supports the exact claim.
Understand a set of documents	NotebookLM or an assistant that can read your files.	That the answer follows the source and preserves caveats.
Design a flyer or visual	Canva or Adobe Express; Photopea for hands-on image editing.	Exact words, readability, asset rights, export quality.
Build a presentation	First write the storyline; then use Google Slides, Canva, or Gamma.	Source evidence, chart labels, and audience clarity.
Check a formula or data pattern	Excel/Google Sheets with an assistant for explanations.	Known examples, edge cases, blanks, dates, duplicates.
Summarize a meeting	Approved notes or an approved transcription tool.	Consent, transcript quality, decisions, owners, deadlines.
Automate an app workflow	Map the process first; then evaluate Make or Zapier.	Plan limits, permissions, failure alerts, duplicate actions.
Improve code	A general assistant or GitHub Copilot in a safe environment.	Tests, dependencies, security, and data-loss risks.
Make a high-stakes decision	A qualified person and authoritative sources. AI may help organize questions.	Never treat the AI answer as the sole authority.

Build a safe starter workspace in 20 minutes

1.
Choose one general assistant that is available to you. Confirm login, region, and usage limits before building a workflow around it.
2.
Create a folder called “AI working examples” and keep only sanitized examples, reusable prompts, and approved outputs inside it.
3.
Save three prompts you will actually reuse: one for drafting, one for summarizing, and one for checking work.
4.
Make a short rule for sensitive data: what must never be entered, which tool is approved for work, and who can approve exceptions.
5.
Choose one low-risk task and record the time it takes without AI. Repeat it with AI and review the result before comparing time.

> **SPEND NOTHING AT FIRST**
>
> Try a free-entry workflow with realistic constraints. Upgrade only after you know what is limiting you, you can measure the benefit, and the specific paid feature is necessary.

The prompt formula

Strong prompts are not magic phrases. They are useful work instructions. Include the pieces that matter for your task:

Ingredient	Question it answers	Example
Role	What helpful perspective should the assistant take?	“Act as a careful project coordinator.”
Task	What should it do?	“Turn the notes into actions and unresolved questions.”
Context	Why, for whom, and under what circumstances?	“The audience is a manager preparing a weekly review.”
Input	What facts or source material may it use?	“Use only the notes below.”
Constraints	What must it preserve or avoid?	“Do not invent owners, dates, costs, or policies.”
Output	What form makes the result usable?	“Return a decision table and a five-bullet summary.”
Acceptance test	How will we know the result is good enough?	“Every action must be traceable to a note; mark gaps.”

Reusable Prompt Skeleton

Act as [useful role]. Help me [specific task]. Context: [audience and purpose]. Input: [paste safe source material]. Constraints: [tone, length, time, budget, rules]. Output: [format]. Acceptance test: [what a correct result must contain]. Use only the supplied facts where required. Mark assumptions and missing information. Ask a question instead of guessing when a missing detail would materially change the result.

Weak prompt vs. useful prompt

Weak request	Stronger request
“Write a report about sales.”	“Prepare a one-page weekly sales update for the store manager using only the figures below. Include trend, three observations, risks, questions, and recommended next steps. Do not infer causes from correlation. Mark calculations for review.”
“Help me study biology.”	“Teach me cell respiration at beginner level in 25 minutes. Start with a plain-language explanation, show one worked example, then quiz me with five questions one at a time. Wait for my answers before showing the key. Flag details I should confirm against my textbook.”
“Give me business ideas.”	“Suggest five online service ideas for [customer group] with budget below [amount]. For each, assess urgency, economic impact, ease of copying, competition, customer willingness to pay, and a low-cost validation test. Separate evidence from assumptions and do not claim guaranteed income.”

The response repair ladder

Problem	Use this follow-up
Too vague	“Make it concrete for [audience and situation]. Give exact steps, an example, and a completion checklist.”
Too long	“Cut this to [length]. Preserve facts, decisions, risks, and qualifications. Remove repetition.”
Unsupported	“For each important factual claim, provide a source that directly supports it. Mark anything you cannot verify.”
Missing details	“Compare the output with these requirements: [list]. Show every missing item, then revise.”
Wrong tone	“Rewrite for [recipient] in a [tone] tone. Keep the facts and desired next step unchanged.”
Ignoring constraints	“My hard constraints are [budget, time, tools, data rules]. Remove options that violate them.”
Likely to cause an error	“List assumptions and failure cases. Propose a safe test on sample data before any irreversible action.”
Pretends to know	“Separate what is known, what is inferred, and what information is unavailable.”

Three-minute practice: repair a weak prompt

Start with: “Write a report about sales.” Add only the information that would change the answer: audience, reporting period, source figures, length, and decision. Then require uncertainty to be flagged.

Try This Version

Using only the sales figures below, prepare a one-page weekly update for [audience]. Include total sales, comparison with [comparison period] if supplied, three observations supported by the figures, risks or missing data, and decisions needed. Do not infer causes. Show calculations and mark any claim that needs verification. Figures: [paste sanitized data].

Self-check: Could a colleague reproduce the totals? Are comparisons based on the same periods? Are observations separated from guesses? Does the final section identify a real next action?

2. Tool directory: choose with a purpose

The list is curated, not exhaustive. Tool entries are intentionally task-led: the goal is not to subscribe to everything, but to choose the smallest dependable stack that fits the work. Use an assistant you already know unless a specialist provides a concrete advantage. Tool selection should account for task fit, reliable output, privacy, accessibility, cost, and the effort of moving work between applications.

> **A SENSIBLE DEFAULT**
>
> Begin with one general assistant and the standard tools you already use. Add a specialist only when it materially improves quality, source traceability, a particular format, or a workflow you repeat often.

A. General assistants and research

Tool	Official site	Best use	Limit to remember
ChatGPT	Open ChatGPT	Drafting, explanations, planning, supported file/image work, and iterative tasks.	Usage caps and enabled tools depend on account, model, region, and current plan.
Google Gemini	Open Gemini	General help and Google-ecosystem tasks where integrations are available.	Usage limits and Workspace features vary by plan and account.
Claude	Open Claude	Long-form drafting, synthesis, careful rewriting, and coding support.	Free access is limited; check current usage and data settings.
Microsoft Copilot	Open Copilot	General help and Microsoft ecosystem workflows.	Do not assume consumer and work accounts have identical protections or features.
Perplexity	Open Perplexity	Research-style answers with links to sources.	A link list does not prove a claim; verify sources independently.
NotebookLM	Open NotebookLM	Questions, summaries, and learning materials grounded in supplied sources.	Sources and features have limits; check that answers match the uploaded source.
Google Scholar	Open Google Scholar	Find scholarly papers, academic literature, and citation trails.	Search ranking is not evidence quality; read the original paper or record.
Google Search	Open Google Search	Find current web pages, official records, and primary sources.	Check the publisher, date, and exact passage supporting each claim.
Elicit	Open Elicit	Explore and organize academic literature.	Research workflows and free allowances may be restricted; verify study details yourself.

B. Writing, language, documents, and learning

Tool	Official site	Best use	Limit to remember
Grammarly	Open Grammarly	Grammar, clarity, tone, and writing suggestions.	Advanced functions and integrations may require a paid plan.
LanguageTool	Open LanguageTool	Grammar, spelling, and multilingual proofreading.	Free checks and language features are limited.
DeepL Translator	Open DeepL	Translation and alternative phrasing.	Review names, idioms, local register, and sensitive wording.

Tool	Official site	Best use	Limit to remember
Google Translate	Open Google Translate	Quick translations and language assistance.	Do not rely on raw output for legally binding, safety-critical, or medical text.
Google Docs	Open Google Docs	Documents, comments, collaborative editing.	AI features vary by account and plan.
Google Sheets	Open Google Sheets	Lists, trackers, basic budgets, and formulas.	Test every generated formula against known cases.
Google Slides	Open Google Slides	Collaborative presentations.	AI features depend on account, plan, and region.
Notion	Open Notion	Notes, knowledge bases, project documentation.	Free AI access may be limited; protect shared workspace permissions.

C. Visuals, designs, and presentations

Tool	Official site	Best use	Limit to remember
Canva	Open Canva	Flyers, social posts, presentation layouts, and branded graphics.	AI allowance, premium assets, and commercial-use conditions vary by plan and asset.
Adobe Express	Open Adobe Express	Templates, social graphics, simple image/video/document edits.	Free and premium assets/features differ; verify asset licenses.
Gamma	Open Gamma	Generate a first structure for presentations and visual docs.	Free credits, slide limits, export options, and branding are plan-dependent.
Photopea	Open Photopea	Browser-based layer and image editing.	Requires manual design judgment; be careful with images used commercially.
remove.bg	Open remove.bg	Quick background removal.	Free output resolution may be limited; inspect edges and rights.
CapCut	Open CapCut	Short-form video editing and captions.	Features, AI credits, and terms differ by region and platform.
Unsplash	Review Unsplash license	Find photos for creative projects.	Check license, context, model/property concerns, and avoid implying false endorsement.

D. Meetings, planning, automation, and code

Tool	Official site	Best use	Limit to remember
Otter	Open Otter	Meeting transcription and summaries when recording is permitted.	Consent, employer rules, import limits, and transcript errors matter.
Tactiq	Open Tactiq	Meeting notes and summaries in supported conferencing workflows.	Confirm meeting participants are informed and policy permits the extension.
Trello	Open Trello	Visual task boards and basic project tracking.	Avoid creating extra process; control who can access boards.
Make	Open Make	No-code workflows that connect supported apps.	Credit/operation limits, app support, failures, and permissions must be checked.

Tool	Official site	Best use	Limit to remember
Zapier	Open Zapier	Connect apps using trigger/action workflows.	Free plan limits change; test task volume and multi-step needs before relying on it.
GitHub Copilot	Open GitHub Copilot	Code suggestions, completion, and developer workflows.	Review generated code, licenses, data settings, dependencies, and security.
Replit	Open Replit	Browser-based coding and app prototypes.	Costs and deployment/security constraints can appear beyond simple prototyping.
Google Colab	Open Google Colab	Run Python notebooks for learning and data experiments.	Runtime availability varies; never upload private data without approval.

How to choose among similar tools

Criterion	Question to ask	Decision rule
Task fit	Can this tool complete the actual step I need?	Reject an impressive tool that does not support the job.
Accuracy and traceability	Can I verify the result or trace it to source material?	For current facts or important research, require opened sources.
Privacy and control	What data will I send, retain, connect, or expose?	Use approved accounts and minimum necessary data.
Practical access	Does it work on my device, in my region, and with my skills?	Prefer accessible workflows over fragile setups.
Cost predictability	What are the limits, exports, credits, and renewal terms?	Calculate the full workflow cost, not just the advertised starting price.
Reliability and fallback	What happens when it fails or reaches a limit?	Have a manual fallback and never automate a critical action without controls.
Exit and reuse	Can I export my work and stop using the tool?	Avoid avoidable lock-in for important records.

Free, trial, and paid are not interchangeable

- Free entry tier: a zero-cost option exists, but usage, export quality, storage, features, speed, or access may be limited.
- Limited complimentary AI use: a product may offer a small number of AI actions, then require an upgrade or a reset.
- Free trial: temporary access may convert to paid billing. Note the end date and cancellation conditions.
- Included in a workplace plan: access may depend on the organization's contract and administrator settings.
- Open source: the software may be available at no license cost, but hosting, setup, computing, support, and maintenance may still cost money.

REFERENCE PAGES TO RECHECK BEFORE ADOPTION

Checks covered OpenAI data controls, Google Gemini limits and privacy, Anthropic plan and data-use guidance, Canva AI allowance guidance, Gamma pricing, and Zapier free-plan documentation. Exact limits, availability, and terms can change; use the linked official sources to confirm the details for your account and region.

3. Step-by-step workflows

Each workflow follows the same pattern: prepare only the information required, ask for a defined output, review the result against a standard, and revise only the failing parts. The prompts are starting points; make them more specific when context changes.

A. Everyday productivity and communication

Workflow 1: Turn a messy task list into a realistic daily plan

Outcome: A prioritized schedule that fits actual time, deadlines, and fixed commitments.

Tools: ChatGPT, Gemini, or Claude; transfer the final plan to your real calendar.

Prepare: Task list, deadlines, fixed appointments, available hours, and estimates if known.

1. List the tasks without trying to organize them first. Mark immovable commitments and deadlines.

2. Ask the assistant to identify dependencies, rough duration ranges, and tasks that can be deferred.

3. Check total planned time against available time. Add buffers for travel, breaks, and interruptions.

4. Choose the top three outcomes for the day and put the approved blocks in your calendar.

> **COPY-READY PROMPT**
>
> Help me make a realistic plan for [date]. Available hours: [hours]. Fixed commitments: [list]. Tasks and deadlines: [list]. Energy or access constraints: [details]. Estimate duration as a range and mark uncertainty. Order tasks by deadline, impact, and dependency. Add buffer time and a short “if the day slips” fallback. Do not schedule more work than fits. Return a time-blocked plan, top three priorities, and items to defer.

Worked example: If there are six hours available and tasks likely need eight, a good result does not squeeze everything into the day. It identifies the highest-impact tasks, proposes what to defer, and shows the unresolved trade-off.

Acceptance check: Every hard deadline is preserved; the total fits available time; estimates are labeled; fixed commitments and buffers are included.

If the tool fails: Use a paper list or calendar if the task is trivial; AI is not necessary for three simple tasks.

Workflow 2: Draft a professional email or difficult message

Outcome: A message with clear purpose, natural tone, and an explicit next step.

Tools: ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini; optional final proofread with Grammarly or LanguageTool.

Prepare: Recipient, relationship, purpose, confirmed facts, desired action, tone, and any deadline.

1. Write the purpose as one sentence and state what you want the recipient to do.

2. Give the assistant only confirmed facts and the tone you want. Say what it must not promise.

3. Read the draft from the recipient’s point of view; remove artificial language and excessive formalities.

4. Check names, dates, attachments, promises, confidentiality, and the final ask before sending.

> **COPY-READY PROMPT**
>
> Draft an email to [recipient/role] about [purpose]. Context: [short facts]. Desired action: [action]. Tone: [direct/warm/formal]. Length: [limit]. Use only the facts supplied. Do not invent dates, attachments, commitments, or policy. Give me a subject line and one polished version. Then list any missing fact that could change the message.

Worked example: For a delayed delivery, the email should acknowledge the delay, state what is confirmed, give an update path, and avoid promising a new date unless one has been approved.

Acceptance check: The request is unmistakable; the tone suits the relationship; every factual claim and promise is confirmed.

Workflow 3: Summarize a long document without losing obligations

Outcome: A useful summary that keeps the source's numbers, caveats, and unresolved issues.

Tools: NotebookLM for a source set, or a file-capable assistant that supports the document type.

Prepare: A document you are allowed to share, the audience, and the decision or task the summary supports.

1. Confirm that you can share the file. Remove identifiers or confidential content not needed for the task.
2. Ask for a structured summary that distinguishes stated facts, interpretations, and missing information.
3. Ask for quotes or page/section pointers for important obligations, deadlines, and figures.
4. Compare every decision-relevant item with the original before using the summary.

> **COPY-READY PROMPT**
>
> Using only the supplied document, prepare a summary for [audience] to support [decision]. Return: (1) summary in [length], (2) important facts and figures with page/section pointers, (3) obligations and deadlines, (4) exceptions and caveats, (5) unresolved questions. Mark anything absent as "not specified." Do not paraphrase a legal or policy obligation in a way that changes its meaning.

Worked example: A policy summary that says "requests are normally reviewed in five days, except where additional documentation is required" must preserve the exception; shortening away the caveat would be a failure.

Acceptance check: Names, figures, dates, thresholds, exceptions, and critical wording match the original source.

Workflow 4: Research a question with traceable sources

Outcome: A short brief that separates confirmed facts, disagreement, and open questions.

Tools: Perplexity or a web-enabled assistant plus Google Search, Scholar, and primary sources.

Prepare: A narrow question, date range, location if relevant, and likely decision use.

1. Turn the topic into a precise question with boundaries such as geography, year, population, or product version.
2. Ask for primary sources first: official documentation, legislation, original research, and direct records.
3. Open each citation. Check the page title, author/publisher, date, context, and the precise supporting passage.
4. Search independently for high-impact claims and note evidence that challenges the first answer.

> **COPY-READY PROMPT**
>
> Research this question: [question]. Scope: [geography/date range/population]. Return a brief with: confirmed findings, conflicting evidence, uncertainties, and what to verify next. Prefer official and primary sources. For each material claim, provide the original source URL, date, and the specific point it supports. Do not invent sources or treat snippets as proof. If evidence is insufficient, say so.

Worked example: For a product feature question, prioritize the official current product help page rather than a blog that repeats an older feature description.

Acceptance check: Each key claim has an opened, relevant source; dates are current enough; uncertainty and counter-evidence are visible.

B. Learning, study, and career

Workflow 5: Learn a difficult topic with practice and feedback

Outcome: A small learning session with explanation, worked example, quiz, and correction.

Tools: ChatGPT, Gemini, Claude; NotebookLM where your supplied course materials are central.

Prepare: Topic, current level, learning goal, time available, and textbook/notes if required.

1. Explain what you already understand and what feels confusing. Specify the learning goal.

2. Ask for a plain-language explanation, then a formal explanation and one worked example.

3. Answer a few questions before asking to see the model answers.

4. Compare definitions and equations against the class material and revisit weak spots.

> **COPY-READY PROMPT**
>
> Teach me [topic] at [level]. Goal: [goal]. Time available: [minutes]. Start with a plain-language explanation and simple analogy. Then give a worked example with steps and common mistakes. Quiz me with five questions one at a time; do not reveal an answer before I try. After each reply, explain the mistake or confirm why it is correct. Flag details to verify against [course source].

Worked example: For a student learning compound interest, the assistant should ask the learner to calculate one example and correct the misunderstanding, not merely generate a finished assignment.

Acceptance check: The learner can answer new practice questions without copying the sample, and course-specific claims match approved materials.

Workflow 6: Build a study plan and active-recall quiz

Outcome: A realistic revision calendar and questions that test memory and application.

Tools: NotebookLM, a general assistant, Google Docs/Sheets, or your existing learning system.

Prepare: Exam date, subjects, weak topics, available study time, and source notes.

1. Rank topics by difficulty, importance, and how much evidence you have of mastery.

2. Break revision into sessions small enough to complete. Include breaks and spaced review.

3. Generate a mix of recall, explanation, comparison, and application questions from the notes.

4. Attempt answers before opening the answer key; log weak areas and schedule a revisit.

> **COPY-READY PROMPT**
>
> Using only the notes below, create a revision plan for [subject] before [date]. Available time: [hours/day]. Prioritize high-weight and weak topics. Include short sessions, spaced review, and one final practice test. Generate [number] flashcards and [number] application questions; put answers separately. Label material not supported by the notes as “verify with course source.” Notes: [paste].

Worked example: On day one, a student reviews two weak topics and does practice questions; on day three the plan schedules retrieval again rather than simply rereading the same notes.

Acceptance check: The schedule fits actual time; the questions cover the supplied material; answer keys are accurate and separated.

Workflow 7: Tailor a CV and job application without inventing experience

Outcome: A targeted but truthful application that maps requirements to evidence.

Tools: ChatGPT, Claude, or Gemini; finalize in a word processor.

Prepare: Sanitized CV, real job description, and employer instructions.

1. Remove personal details not necessary for editing; use a sanitized CV where possible.

2. Ask for a requirement-to-evidence gap table before rewriting the CV.

3. Rewrite bullet points around real actions, scope, and measurable results only where facts are supplied.

4. Compare the final document with the original CV and the employer’s requested format.

> **COPY-READY PROMPT**
>
> Compare my sanitized CV with this job description. First return a table: requirement, evidence in my CV, gap, and truthful next step. Then improve wording for clarity and relevance using only facts supplied. Do not invent employers, qualifications, skills,

> dates, achievements, or metrics. Mark any wording that requires my confirmation. Keep it natural and readable. CV: [paste]. Job description: [paste].

Worked example: If a job asks for SQL and the CV only mentions Excel, the output should identify SQL as a gap and suggest a learning or demonstration project - not claim the applicant has SQL experience.

Acceptance check: Every credential, date, achievement, tool, metric, and responsibility is true and can be explained in an interview.

Workflow 8: Prepare for an interview

Outcome: Structured practice with evidence-based answers, not memorized fiction.

Tools: A general assistant and a copy of the real job description.

Prepare: Job description, real experience examples, and areas of concern.

1. Identify the main competencies and likely question types in the job description.
2. Choose truthful examples using situation, task, action, and result when that format fits.
3. Practice one question at a time; answer before requesting feedback.
4. Revise for specificity and clarity, then practice aloud without reading the full script.

> **COPY-READY PROMPT**
>
> Act as an interviewer for [role]. Use this job description: [paste]. Ask one question at a time. Wait for my answer. Evaluate relevance, clarity, evidence, and honesty. Suggest a stronger structure using only my experience. Do not invent stories or results. At the end, list the three areas I should prepare next.

Worked example: A candidate gives a real example of resolving a customer issue; the assistant helps highlight the steps and outcome without manufacturing a percentage or claiming sole credit.

Acceptance check: Answers are specific, truthful, concise, and supported by an example the candidate can discuss naturally.

C. Freelancers, small business, and customer work

Workflow 9: Validate a business idea before spending money

Outcome: A testable set of assumptions and a cheap validation plan, not a promise of income.

Tools: ChatGPT/Claude/Gemini for structuring; Google Search, public data, and customer interviews for evidence.

Prepare: Target customer, problem, proposed solution, constraints, and amount/time you can risk.

1. Describe a specific customer and the task/problem they already spend time or money trying to solve.
2. Ask the assistant to challenge the idea and name the riskiest assumptions first.
3. Check existing alternatives and conduct neutral interviews about current behavior, frequency, cost, and urgency.
4. Run the smallest ethical test before paying for subscriptions, ads, or inventory; define pass/fail signals in advance.

> **COPY-READY PROMPT**
>
> Act as a skeptical market researcher. Idea: [idea]. Customer: [specific group]. Problem: [problem]. Current workaround: [alternatives]. Budget/time: [limits]. List the riskiest assumptions, the evidence each needs, a low-cost test, neutral interview questions, a pass/fail signal, and the next decision. Include reasons customers may not pay and who already solves this problem. Do not claim demand, market size, or guaranteed revenue without evidence.

Worked example: An idea for a bookkeeping reminder service might be tested by interviewing a few relevant business owners and offering a small manual pilot before buying automation software. Interest is weaker evidence than a paid pilot.

Acceptance check: Actual behavior and willingness to pay are tested; the plan includes a stop condition and does not treat AI-generated optimism as market evidence.

Workflow 10: Create a customer FAQ and approved reply library

Outcome: Consistent support drafts based only on approved policy and product facts.

Tools: ChatGPT/Claude for drafting; Google Docs or Notion for controlled publication.

Prepare: Approved terms, product facts, support policies, escalation contacts, and review owner.

1. Collect the approved source of truth and remove irrelevant customer information.
2. Generate common questions and short answers, with separate steps when needed.
3. Ask for an explicit "not specified" status wherever the source does not answer the question.
4. Have a policy owner approve the replies and set a review date before publication.

> **COPY-READY PROMPT**
>
> Using only this approved policy, draft a FAQ for [product/service] and audience [audience]. Include question, short answer, required steps, and when to contact a human. Do not invent prices, delivery dates, refunds, warranties, eligibility, or guarantees. Mark missing information "owner confirmation required." Flag billing, privacy, safety, legal, and exceptional cases for escalation. Source policy: [paste].

Worked example: If the refund policy explains eligibility but not processing time, the answer should say the processing time requires owner confirmation - not invent "3-5 business days."

Acceptance check: Every answer matches the approved policy; unsupported answers are flagged; an owner is responsible for maintenance.

Workflow 11: Plan useful content for a small business

Outcome: A manageable calendar with a real audience problem, useful information, and clear claims to check.

Tools: ChatGPT/Claude for planning; Canva or Adobe Express for graphics; existing platform analytics for review.

Prepare: Customer group, offer, location/market if relevant, audience questions, posting capacity, and approved claims.

1. Choose two or three customer problems that your product can honestly help with.
2. Create distinct content pillars such as how-to, FAQ, comparison, behind the scenes, and customer education.
3. Ask for a calendar sized to your actual time and channels, with one useful takeaway per post.
4. Check every claim, link, price, image right, and CTA before publishing; measure meaningful responses, not only likes.

> **COPY-READY PROMPT**
>
> Create a [2-week/1-month] content calendar for [business/topic]. Audience: [customer group]. Offer: [offer]. Platforms: [platforms]. Publishing capacity: [posts/week]. For every post provide audience problem, topic, hook, useful point, format, draft caption, gentle CTA, and claim/assets to verify. Do not invent customer testimonials, statistics, endorsements, product capabilities, or scarcity. Keep all posts possible within my time budget.

Worked example: A local repair service might post a checklist for preparing a device for repair, explain what affects turnaround time, and answer common warranty questions instead of publishing repetitive promotional captions.

Acceptance check: Every post serves a customer need, facts are confirmed, publishing volume is sustainable, and there is a clear way to review real responses.

Workflow 12: Write a service proposal or scope of work

Outcome: A proposal that makes the problem, deliverables, boundaries, approvals, and acceptance criteria clear.

Tools: A general assistant, Google Docs, or a proposal template already used by your business.

Prepare: Customer brief, real capability, timeline, assumptions, exclusions, and approved pricing if known.

1. Summarize what the client needs and what success would look like in observable terms.

2. Separate confirmed scope from assumptions, exclusions, dependencies, and client responsibilities.

3. Ask for deliverables and acceptance criteria rather than vague promises.

4. Review pricing, dates, terms, and commitments with the person who can approve them.

> **COPY-READY PROMPT**
>
> Draft a proposal for [client type] solving [problem]. Confirmed facts: [facts]. Deliverables: [list]. Timeline constraints: [details]. Pricing: [approved amount or "not yet set"]. Include objective, scope, deliverables, exclusions, assumptions, dependencies, milestones, acceptance criteria, revision limits, risks, and questions requiring approval. Do not invent credentials, prices, guarantees, or legal terms.

Worked example: A graphic-design proposal can specify two initial concepts, one agreed final design, file formats, and what counts as an extra revision rather than saying "unlimited edits."

Acceptance check: All promises can be delivered; payment, scope, schedule, acceptance, revision, and change-control terms are clear and approved.

Workflow 13: Turn a manual process into an SOP

Outcome: A process another trained person can follow, including exceptions and escalation.

Tools: General assistant for formatting; Google Docs/Notion for the controlled document; actual process owner for validation.

Prepare: Observed steps, roles, required tools/permissions, known exceptions, and escalation contacts.

1. Observe or describe the current process. Do not ask the model to invent steps it cannot know.

2. Give the assistant the confirmed notes and ask it to mark information gaps explicitly.

3. Ask a process owner to confirm safety, access, approvals, and exception handling.

4. Test the SOP with a person who did not write it and record any point that requires interpretation.

> **COPY-READY PROMPT**
>
> Turn these confirmed notes into an SOP for [role]. Include purpose, scope, owner, prerequisites, tools/permissions, numbered steps, expected result at each step, quality checks, exception handling, escalation route, records created, safety/privacy notes, version, approval date, and review date. Do not invent policies or authorities. Mark unknowns "owner confirmation required." Notes: [paste].

Worked example: An order-processing SOP should define what to do when payment confirmation is missing and who can approve a refund, rather than only describing the happy path.

Acceptance check: A new user can perform the process; exceptions are covered; approval rights and current owner are confirmed.

D. Data, meetings, presentations, and technical work

Workflow 14: Use AI to explain or draft a spreadsheet formula

Outcome: A formula supported by examples and tests before use on real data.

Tools: Excel or Google Sheets plus an assistant for explanation.

Prepare: App/version, locale if relevant, column names, a few sanitized rows, and the expected result.

1. Work on a copy of the spreadsheet and remove private identifiers.

2. Describe column meanings, data types, blank/duplicate behavior, and the exact output needed.

3. Ask for a formula, an explanation, test rows with expected results, and any simpler built-in option.

4. Test normal, blank, duplicate, malformed, and boundary cases before applying it to the full sheet.

> **COPY-READY PROMPT**

> I use [Excel/Google Sheets]. Goal: [task]. Columns and meanings: [details]. Example rows: [sanitized sample]. Expected output: [describe]. Suggest a formula and explain each part. State assumptions about blanks, duplicate values, dates, text, and currency. Give at least three test cases with expected results, including an edge case. Tell me whether my locale may require different separators. Do not assume unseen data formats.

Worked example: If column C contains expense categories and D contains amounts, ask for a category total and test it on a tiny hand-checked table before copying the formula down.

Acceptance check: Manually computed test results match the formula; the original data is preserved; the output makes sense for edge cases.

Workflow 15: Turn meeting notes into follow-through

Outcome: A recap separating decisions, actions, owners, dates, risks, and open questions.

Tools: Approved notes or approved transcription; assistant for structuring; Google Docs or a team workspace for final sharing.

Prepare: Meeting purpose, sanitized notes/transcript, and participant consent/policy confirmation where recording is used.

1. Use notes you are allowed to share. If recording was involved, confirm consent and organizational rules.
2. Ask the assistant to separate decisions from suggestions and explicit assignments from inferred ones.
3. Create an action table and mark owner/date as “not assigned” or “not specified” when missing.
4. Send the recap to participants to correct inaccuracies and confirm action ownership.

> **COPY-READY PROMPT**
>
> Turn these notes into a meeting follow-up. Return (1) summary in five bullets, (2) confirmed decisions, (3) action table with task, owner, due date, supporting note, and status, (4) risks/dependencies, and (5) open questions. Do not infer owner, deadline, or approval. Mark absent details “not specified.” Separate decisions from ideas. Notes: [paste sanitized notes].

Worked example: Notes: “Mina will draft the FAQ. Launch date still needs confirmation.” A good action table records Mina as owner for the FAQ, but does not invent a launch date.

Acceptance check: Every decision/action is traceable to notes; unassigned tasks remain unassigned; owners confirm the recap.

Workflow 16: Create a presentation that drives a decision

Outcome: A storyline in which each slide has one point supported by evidence.

Tools: General assistant for outline; Google Slides, Canva, or Gamma for layout.

Prepare: Audience, decision/learning goal, time limit, key message, known evidence, and brand requirements.

1. State what the audience should understand or decide after the presentation.
2. Ask for a slide outline where each headline states a conclusion, not a generic topic.
3. Attach evidence needs to every statistic and chart; fill evidence gaps before design polish.
4. Review slide density, contrast, reading order, chart labels, and the deck without speaker narration.

> **COPY-READY PROMPT**
>
> Create a presentation outline for [audience] about [topic]. Purpose: [decision/update/learning]. Duration: [minutes]. Main takeaway: [one sentence]. For each slide provide the key-message headline, 3-5 supporting points, evidence/source required, suggested visual, and speaker note. Do not invent statistics. Finish with the decision or next steps, including owner and date only where supplied.

Worked example: An operations update should lead with the decision needed, show the few indicators that support it, then list risks and options - not start with five generic agenda slides.

Acceptance check: Each slide has one main point; factual claims have evidence; the ask or conclusion is explicit; the deck is readable on screen.

Workflow 17: Debug code or an automation safely

Outcome: A small, testable fix supported by evidence rather than an unverified rewrite.

Tools: GitHub Copilot, Replit, or a general assistant; test in a safe environment.

Prepare: Expected behavior, actual behavior, exact error, version/environment, minimal sanitized code, and tests.

1. Reproduce the problem and save the current version before changing code or workflows.
2. Share only the smallest relevant example; remove tokens, passwords, customer data, and secrets.
3. Ask for ranked likely causes, the evidence for each, and the smallest safe fix.
4. Run tests for normal, boundary, and failure cases; review security, permissions, and dependencies.

> **COPY-READY PROMPT**
>
> Help debug this [language/tool] issue. Expected behavior: [expected]. Actual behavior: [actual]. Exact error: [message]. Version/environment: [details]. Minimal sanitized example: [code]. Rank likely causes by evidence. Suggest the smallest fix and explain why. Include tests for normal, boundary, and failure cases. Flag security, data-loss, performance, and dependency risks. Do not assume missing environment details.

Worked example: If a spreadsheet automation duplicates rows, test with one new record, one duplicate, and one missing required field before running the workflow on the full table.

Acceptance check: The issue is reproducible and the fix passes tests; no secrets are present; a rollback path exists.

Workflow 18: Design a no-code automation that can fail safely

Outcome: A documented trigger-to-result workflow with alerts, limits, and a manual fallback.

Tools: Map by hand first; then test Make or Zapier against official plan and app capability pages.

Prepare: Trigger, inputs, steps, output, expected frequency/volume, exceptions, data class, and owner.

1. Write down the current manual process, including exceptions and who owns each step.
2. Define trigger, transformation, destination, duplicate prevention, error handling, and required permissions.
3. Build a small version using fake/test records; inspect logs and task/credit use.
4. Keep a manual fallback, alert owner, and a clear stop switch before enabling live traffic.

> **COPY-READY PROMPT**
>
> Design an automation for [repetitive task] across [apps]. Trigger: [event]. Inputs: [fields]. Desired result: [output]. Volume: [frequency]. Exceptions: [cases]. Data sensitivity: [level]. Return the trigger, steps, conditions, permissions, duplicate control, failure alerts, estimated limit factors to verify, test cases, owner, and a manual fallback. Do not ask for passwords or private records.

Worked example: A contact form may add a lead to a spreadsheet, but a duplicate key and an alert for failed runs should exist before a team depends on it.

Acceptance check: Duplicates, missing fields, permissions, failures, and costs are tested; a human can detect and recover from errors.

E. Home and personal organization

Workflow 19: Plan meals, errands, or household routines

Outcome: A realistic household plan that uses available time, resources, and budget.

Tools: General assistant and an actual calendar, shopping list, or note app.

Prepare: Household constraints, budget/currency, time, available ingredients/resources, equipment, and verified dietary requirements.

1. List constraints and existing resources first; distinguish a hard restriction from a preference.

2. Ask for a plan that reuses supplies and includes lower-effort alternatives for busy days.

3. Check local availability and current prices manually; do not treat generated prices as live data.

4. Inspect product packaging and reliable guidance for allergies and safety.

> **COPY-READY PROMPT**
>
> Plan [a week of meals / household chores / errands]. People and needs: [details]. Schedule: [hours]. Budget and currency: [amount]. Available resources: [list]. Hard restrictions: [list]. Produce a realistic schedule, prep steps, a consolidated list, estimated time, lower-effort alternatives, and items whose price or availability needs checking. Do not assume an allergy is safe without verified evidence.

Worked example: A weekly meal plan built around ingredients already at home and two easy backup meals is usually more usable than seven complicated recipes requiring many special purchases.

Acceptance check: The plan matches real restrictions, time and budget; uncertain prices/availability are labeled; safety information is checked externally.

Workflow 20: Translate and localize public-facing communication

Outcome: A translation that keeps meaning while matching audience and locale.

Tools: DeepL or Google Translate for a first pass; a fluent or qualified reviewer for high-impact copy.

Prepare: Source text, target language/locale, audience, purpose, terms that must remain unchanged.

1. Specify locale and audience, not only language (for example, formal customer service versus informal social copy).

2. Protect names, dates, quantities, product terms, and commitments explicitly.

3. Ask the assistant to flag phrases with multiple possible interpretations and provide alternatives.

4. Use a qualified reviewer for legal, medical, safety, or high-value commercial material.

> **COPY-READY PROMPT**
>
> Translate this text from [source language] to [target language and locale]. Audience: [audience]. Purpose: [purpose]. Tone: [tone]. Preserve names, dates, numbers, product terms, and commitments. Do not add or remove meaning. After translating, list ambiguities and suggest alternative phrasings where needed. Text: [paste].

Worked example: A customer message should not become more apologetic, make a new promise, or change a refund commitment simply because the target language normally uses a warmer tone.

Acceptance check: The translation preserves intent, names, figures, and obligations; a fluent speaker reviews high-impact wording.

F. Research, decisions, and higher-value delivery

Workflow 21: Turn research into a decision brief

Outcome: A concise brief that separates evidence, interpretation, options, trade-offs, and the decision still required.

Tools: A web-enabled assistant or Perplexity for discovery; official sources, primary records, and a document editor for the final brief.

Prepare: The decision question, audience, deadline, geographic scope if relevant, reliable sources, and constraints.

1. Write the decision question as a question that can change an action, not as a broad topic.

2. Collect primary sources first where possible; record publication dates, evidence, and limitations.

3. Ask the assistant to organize findings into evidence, interpretation, uncertainty, options, and missing data.

4. Open sources and verify that each important claim is supported by the exact cited material.

5. Rewrite the conclusion so it states what evidence supports, what it does not support, and what would change the decision.

> **COPY-READY PROMPT**
>
> Prepare a decision brief for [decision-maker]. Decision question: [specific question]. Scope/date range: [scope]. Source pack: [links or approved documents]. Constraints: [budget, time, policy, geography]. Return an executive summary, verified facts with source links and dates, conflicting evidence, assumptions, three feasible options, trade-offs, unresolved questions, and a recommendation only where evidence supports one. Do not invent statistics, turn correlation into causation, or imply that a source was checked if it was not. Mark each important claim that still needs human confirmation.

Worked example: For choosing a customer-support platform, compare actual workflow needs, current published limits, total cost, data controls, exports, and vendor lock-in rather than ranking products from feature lists alone.

Acceptance check: Every decision-critical claim is traceable to an opened source; dates and limitations are visible; assumptions are separate from facts; the decision owner can see what remains unresolved.

Workflow 22: Design customer interviews and synthesize feedback

Outcome: A neutral interview guide and an evidence-based summary of recurring customer problems without pretending a small sample represents the whole market.

Tools: A general assistant for guide design and coding; an approved notes/document workspace for source-of-truth feedback.

Prepare: Research objective, customer segment, consent approach, interview notes with identifiers removed, and known sampling limitations.

1. Define what decision the interviews should inform and what uncertainty you need to reduce.

2. Ask for open-ended questions that invite examples of past behavior, workarounds, costs, and urgency rather than praise for your idea.

3. Run interviews consistently and record only information participants have agreed to share.

4. Remove identifying details before using AI to group notes; keep quotations traceable to your own source records.

5. Ask the assistant to identify themes, counterexamples, evidence strength, and questions for the next round.

> **COPY-READY PROMPT**
>
> Design a 20-minute customer interview for [customer group] to investigate [problem]. Do not pitch my solution or lead the participant. Give an opening consent statement, 8-10 open questions about recent real behavior, workarounds, consequences, urgency, alternatives, and spending decisions, plus neutral follow-ups. Then provide a coding framework for later notes. When synthesizing notes, separate direct evidence, interpretation, minority views, and unanswered questions; never generalize a small convenience sample to the entire market. Context: [brief].

Worked example: Instead of asking “Would you pay for our app?”, ask “Tell me about the last time this problem occurred. What did you do, how long did it take, and what did it cost?”

Acceptance check: Questions are neutral; consent and minimization are respected; conclusions include counterevidence and sample limits; willingness-to-pay is grounded in behavior, not compliments.

Workflow 23: Create a product page with substantiated claims

Outcome: A product/service page with clear audience, benefits, proof, boundaries, and one next action, without fabricated testimonials or promises.

Tools: A general assistant for structure and copy; actual product records, approved claims, and the publishing platform for verification.

Prepare: Verified features, price and terms, genuine evidence, target customer, restrictions, and the desired next action.

1. List what the offer definitely includes, excludes, costs, requires, and cannot guarantee.

2. Gather support for each performance claim, testimonial, comparison, certification, and customer outcome.

3. Generate a page structure that starts with the customer problem and explains the offer in plain language.

4. Ask the assistant to flag vague superlatives, implied guarantees, missing terms, and claims without evidence.

5. Check final copy against actual product behavior and the laws and policies that apply to your market.

> **COPY-READY PROMPT**
>
> Draft a product/service page for [offer] aimed at [customer]. Verified inclusions: [facts]. Exclusions and limits: [facts]. Price/terms: [verified details]. Evidence available: [proof]. Desired action: [CTA]. Produce a headline, subhead, problem statement, benefit sections tied to real features, how it works, who it is and is not for, FAQs, limitations, and CTA. Do not invent testimonials, results, certifications, scarcity, prices, or guarantees. Create a separate claim-check table with each claim, supporting evidence, and approval needed. If evidence is missing, rewrite the claim modestly or flag it.

Worked example: A bookkeeping service page can promise a defined monthly reconciliation process if true, but should not promise “zero tax problems” or claim client savings without substantiation.

Acceptance check: Every material claim has evidence or is removed; price, scope, exclusions, and terms are clear; testimonials and endorsements are genuine and properly authorized.

Workflow 24: Review a policy or agreement for questions to resolve

Outcome: A structured issues list for a qualified owner or adviser, not an AI-generated legal opinion or substitute for professional advice.

Tools: A file-capable assistant or source-grounded notebook; the original agreement/policy and qualified reviewer.

Prepare: The complete document you are permitted to share, version/date, business context, review purpose, and applicable professional/legal owner.

1. Confirm permission to upload the document and remove personal, confidential, or privileged data unless approved handling is in place.

2. Ask for a neutral inventory of obligations, deadlines, fees, renewal/termination terms, exceptions, and ambiguous language with page/section references.

3. Require uncertainty to be marked and ask the assistant to quote only the minimum text needed to identify an issue.

4. Compare the inventory against the original; check that no exception, schedule, attachment, or defined term was missed.

5. Send the issues list to the qualified owner or lawyer before relying on it or taking action.

> **COPY-READY PROMPT**
>
> Review this document only to prepare questions for [qualified reviewer/business owner]. Purpose: [purpose]. Version/date: [details]. Identify obligations, dates, renewal and termination rules, fees, discretion, exceptions, data/security duties, liability/indemnity language, and unclear terms. For every item provide the page/section, short paraphrase, practical question, and confidence/uncertainty. Do not tell me whether it is legally enforceable, do not make a legal conclusion, and do not infer provisions absent from the text. List missing attachments or referenced terms that need to be obtained. Document: [approved file/text].

Worked example: For a supplier agreement, a useful review flags an auto-renewal clause and asks the owner to confirm the notice deadline; it does not assume the clause is invalid or recommend ignoring it.

Acceptance check: All issue references match the original document; missing attachments are explicit; a qualified reviewer handles legal interpretations and consequential action.

Workflow 25: Turn a small dataset into an executive insight brief

Outcome: A concise data story that includes validated metrics, sensible comparisons, uncertainty, and practical next questions.

Tools: Excel or Google Sheets for calculations; an assistant to structure hypotheses and narrative; a human analyst for validation.

Prepare: A clean, authorized dataset, field definitions, reporting period, known data limitations, and one business question.

1. Keep the original data unchanged and work from a copy; remove unnecessary identifiers.
2. Inspect missing values, duplicates, units, date ranges, category spelling, and any filtering that changes the result.
3. Calculate key totals and comparisons with the spreadsheet or statistical tool, then independently reproduce a sample.
4. Ask the assistant to draft observations only from supplied metrics and distinguish patterns from explanations.
5. Review the brief for denominator changes, small samples, misleading axes, seasonality, and unsupported causal claims.

> **COPY-READY PROMPT**
>
> Help prepare a data brief about [business question]. Dataset description: [fields, units, period, row count]. Metrics already calculated: [figures and formulas]. Data quality issues: [known issues]. Audience: [reader]. Return five parts: (1) three evidence-backed observations, (2) what changed versus the comparison period if comparable, (3) limitations, (4) hypotheses that require further testing, and (5) decisions/questions. Do not invent metrics, infer causation, conceal missing data, or make recommendations unsupported by the data. For each observation, show the exact metric and the check needed before publication.

Worked example: A rise in monthly revenue alongside a rise in order count supports a statement about both observed metrics; it does not prove that a campaign caused the change without additional evidence.

Acceptance check: Totals can be reproduced; dates and denominators are comparable; observations cite the actual metrics; limitations and causal uncertainty are visible.

4. Worked examples: from prompt to usable result

These examples use fictional or generic information. They illustrate what a practical output should look like, not a claim that an AI tool will always return it correctly. Run the checks independently.

Example A. A realistic day plan

Input: Available work time is 9:00-12:00 and 13:00-16:00. A client draft is due at 15:00 (90 minutes). A bank reconciliation takes an estimated 60 minutes and should be completed today. Email replies take 45 minutes. A non-urgent reading task takes 90 minutes. There is a fixed meeting from 10:00-10:30, a 30-minute lunch, and a 30-minute midday buffer.

Proposed block	Work	Reason
09:00-09:15	Review urgent messages and confirm priorities	Catch any deadline changes before committing.
09:15-09:45	Client draft - first pass	Protect a near-term deliverable before the meeting.
09:45-10:00	Meeting prep / short buffer	Prepare for the fixed meeting.
10:00-10:30	Fixed meeting	Immovable commitment.
10:30-11:15	Client draft - finish	Continue the near-term deliverable after the meeting.
11:15-12:00	Email replies	Bound a task with a defined time limit.
12:00-12:30	Lunch	Protected meal break.
12:30-13:00	Midday buffer	Time for overruns or interruptions.
13:00-14:00	Bank reconciliation	Complete today's finance-sensitive task while focused.
14:00-14:15	Final check and send client draft	The full drafting and review time totals 90 minutes.
14:15-14:45	Overflow buffer / unexpected requests	Do not pre-fill every minute.
14:45-15:00	Deadline buffer	Confirm delivery and absorb small overruns.
15:00-16:00	Start reading task or defer if interrupted	A lower-urgency task uses remaining time only if possible.

WHAT THE EXAMPLE TEACHES

A useful plan protects fixed commitments, reserves a verification buffer, and makes trade-offs explicit. It does not claim to predict exactly how long every person will take.

Example B. Meeting notes to action table

Sanitized notes: “We agreed to trial the revised onboarding email with ten new users. Chidi will prepare the draft. Amara raised a concern about missing consent language; Legal review is still needed. No launch date agreed. The team will meet again next week.”

Type	Item	Owner	Due date	Evidence/status
Decision	Trial revised onboarding email with ten new users.	Team	Not specified	Explicitly agreed in notes.

Type	Item	Owner	Due date	Evidence/status
Action	Prepare draft email.	Chidi	Not specified	Named owner; no date stated.
Open issue	Confirm consent language.	Not assigned	Not specified	Legal review required; reviewer not named.
Next step	Schedule next meeting.	Not assigned	Next week; exact date not specified	Notes specify week only.

Do not let the AI transform “Legal review is still needed” into “Legal approved,” or “next week” into a specific date. Unknowns should remain visible so someone can resolve them.

Example C. Simple expense summary in a spreadsheet

Suppose a clean copy of a spreadsheet has these columns: A = Date, B = Category, C = Description, D = Amount. First test with a few fictional rows and manually compute the correct category total.

Date	Category	Description	Amount
2026-10-01	Transport	Bus fare	1500
2026-10-02	Food	Lunch	2800
2026-10-03	Transport	Taxi	4500
2026-10-04	Utilities	Data plan	3000
2026-10-05	Food	Groceries	6700

To total Transport in a formula, one possible Google Sheets/Excel formula is =SUMIF(B2:B6,"Transport",D2:D6). In this tiny sample, the expected result is 6,000. The expected result is the known-good test result. Do not accept a formula only because it looks plausible.

Before using a full dataset, test what happens when a category is misspelled, an amount is blank, a date is text, or the same transaction appears twice. Spreadsheet locale settings may change separators or date parsing.

Example D. A useful small-business post

Business: a fictional phone-repair shop. Audience problem: customers are unsure what information to bring when requesting a repair quote.

Weak output	More useful output
“We are the best repair shop! Contact us today for amazing services.”	“Before requesting a phone-repair quote, note your device model, the problem you see, when it started, and whether the phone was dropped or exposed to liquid. Do not share your password. We will confirm next steps after inspecting the device. Message us with your model and issue to start.”

The stronger post gives useful steps, avoids unsupported “best” claims, gives a clear next action, and does not encourage sharing sensitive credentials.

Example E. CV tailoring without inventing a credential

Job requirement: “Experience supporting customers and documenting issues.” Supplied CV evidence: “Answered customer questions at a retail counter and recorded stock issues in a daily log.”

Requirement	Existing evidence	Safe revision	Do not claim
Customer support	Answered customer questions in a retail role.	“Responded to customer questions at the retail counter and directed issues to the appropriate team.”	Do not claim formal call-centre experience unless supplied.

Requirement	Existing evidence	Safe revision	Do not claim
Documentation	Recorded stock issues in a daily log.	"Maintained daily records of stock issues to support follow-up."	Do not claim a ticketing system or CRM if not used.

Example F. Automation acceptance tests

Use these tests before a workflow that receives form submissions and creates records:

Test	Input / situation	Expected behavior
Normal	Complete valid form, new email/ID.	One record created; owner receives notification.
Duplicate	Submit same identifier twice.	Duplicate detected, or second action blocked/flagged.
Missing field	Required email or ID blank.	Workflow rejects, routes for review, or alerts the owner.
Connection failure	Destination app is unavailable.	Failure logged and notification sent; record can be retried safely.
Permission removed	Connector loses required access.	No silent success; owner receives a clear alert.
Volume cap	Expected run volume approaches plan limit.	Limit is visible; workflow owner has a fallback before interruption.

5. Playbooks by audience

Start with the smallest useful workflow for your role. Keep the first week low-risk; once the result is reliable, save the prompt and the checklist so the work can be repeated.

Students and lifelong learners

Good starting uses: explain a concept, turn notes into practice questions, compare a topic against source material, practice a language, and organize revision. These uses support learning when the learner still attempts the work.

Start this week	How to use AI well	Avoid
Explain one difficult topic	Ask for a simple explanation, worked example, quiz, and correction.	Copying a finished assignment without understanding or violating school rules.
Build revision questions	Use only your notes and keep the answer key separate.	Memorizing AI-generated facts that are missing or wrong.
Prepare a research question	Ask for source types and search terms, then read original sources.	Citing a paper or quote you have not opened.
Practice an exam	Ask one question at a time, answer first, then receive feedback.	Treating an AI score as an official grade or certification.

Professionals and job seekers

Start this week	How to use AI well	Avoid
Draft one recurring email	Give audience, desired action, confirmed facts, and word limit.	Sending without checking recipient, dates, attachments, and commitments.
Create a meeting follow-up	Separate decisions, actions, owners, deadlines, and open questions.	Inferring an owner or deadline from a vague discussion.
Tailor one application	Map job requirements to evidence in the actual CV.	Inventing experience, credentials, or metrics.
Prepare a weekly update	Summarize supplied progress, evidence, risks, and decisions needed.	Letting the model create status numbers or claims without data.

Freelancers

Use AI to reduce repetitive drafting and raise the consistency of delivery, but do not confuse a finished-looking draft with a sellable service. A client pays for solving the problem accurately, communicating clearly, and delivering within scope.

Service workflow	Practical AI role	Human control
Client intake	Turn a brief into requirements, questions, deadlines, and missing inputs.	Confirm scope and client expectations.
Proposal and scope	Draft objective, deliverables, assumptions, exclusions, milestones, and acceptance criteria.	Approve price, schedule, commitments, and terms.
Delivery	Create a first draft, outline, content variations, or data-cleaning plan.	Apply subject skill and verify final output.
Quality assurance	Compare output against a checklist and flag inconsistencies.	Resolve every critical issue before handoff.
Client handoff	Write a clear summary, files list, assumptions, and next actions.	Confirm the deliverables match the agreement.

A Practical Freelancer Rule

Do not sell raw AI text as specialist expertise. Sell a defined outcome, apply judgment, verify the result, protect client data, and make the scope and acceptance criteria clear.

Small businesses

Business need	Starter workflow	Measure
Customer support	Draft replies from approved policy and flag exceptions.	First-response time, correction rate, escalation accuracy.
Marketing	Build a calendar from real customer problems and approved facts.	Qualified inquiries, saves/clicks where relevant, repeat questions reduced.
Operations	Document one process that relies on memory.	Time to train, mistakes, missing steps, process completion.
Admin	Summarize sanitized notes and generate action lists.	Minutes spent and number of follow-up clarifications.
Finance admin	Explain formulas, categorize dummy data, spot anomalies.	Reconciliation accuracy; no AI-only payment/tax decision.

Households and personal organization

Start with low-stakes planning: weekly meal ideas from ingredients you already have, a household shopping list, a calendar that respects real commitments, or an explanation of a confusing document. Check prices, local availability, product labels, and any safety-related detail manually. Do not share passwords, banking identifiers, or private details simply to make a plan more specific.

Corporate teams and managers

The team question is not only whether an AI feature works. It is also whether the tool is approved for the data and use case, whether the result can be verified, who approves the final action, and what happens when something fails.

Use case	Guardrail	Required evidence before rollout
Internal knowledge search	Use approved repositories and access controls; do not bypass permissions.	Source coverage, access tests, correct citations, fallback when documents disagree.
Customer support drafting	Answers must use approved policy; sensitive cases escalate.	Policy-based test set, exception coverage, named human approver.
Meeting follow-up	Consent and company rules; transcript accuracy is checked.	Participant notice, correction route, confirmed owners/dates.
Data analysis	Use synthetic/sanitized data for prototyping; preserve originals.	Reproducible calculations, test cases, access and retention review.
Code assistance	Secure development lifecycle, review, tests, dependency checks.	Security tests, license review as applicable, human code owner.
Automation	Least privilege, monitoring, duplicate prevention, rollback.	Normal and failure tests, alert path, cost/limit review, manual fallback.

A starter stack for people who want to keep things simple

Role / need	Simple starting stack	Add complexity only when…
Student	One general assistant + course notes + Docs/Sheets.	You need source-grounded work across many files or a learning tracker.

Role / need	Simple starting stack	Add complexity only when...
Office professional	One assistant approved for the task + existing Word/Docs and calendar.	A recurring workflow needs a specialist or integration.
Freelancer	One assistant + document editor + a simple project tracker.	Client volume justifies intake automation or controlled templates.
Small business	One assistant + approved FAQ/source doc + Sheets + design tool.	There is clear demand, owner capacity, and evidence automation reduces work.
Corporate team	Organization-approved AI suite + source-of-truth repository + review SOP.	Security, legal, procurement, and IT approve the use case and controls.

6. Copy-ready prompt library

Replace bracketed items with your own details. Do not paste data you are not permitted to share. For a high-impact task, add an acceptance test and ask the assistant to flag unknowns.

Prompts organized by task

Everyday planning: Prioritize tasks

COPY AND CUSTOMIZE

Sort these tasks by deadline, impact, effort, and dependencies. I have [time] available. Include a realistic sequence, buffer time, tasks to defer, and the three most important outcomes. Mark uncertain duration estimates. Tasks: [paste].

Everyday planning: Weekly plan

COPY AND CUSTOMIZE

Create a weekly plan around these fixed commitments: [list]. Goals: [goals]. Available time: [hours]. Constraints: [constraints]. Add buffer and a 15-minute weekly review. Do not overbook time.

Writing: Professional email

COPY AND CUSTOMIZE

Draft a concise email to [recipient] about [purpose]. Context: [facts]. Desired action: [action]. Tone: [tone]. Use only supplied facts; do not invent dates, promises, policy, or attachments. Flag missing details.

Writing: Improve a draft

COPY AND CUSTOMIZE

Edit this draft for clarity, structure, grammar, and natural tone. Preserve meaning and all factual qualifications. List any sentence whose meaning is ambiguous rather than guessing. Draft: [paste].

Writing: Difficult conversation

COPY AND CUSTOMIZE

Help me prepare a respectful conversation about [issue]. Separate observed facts, impact, questions, and request. Offer neutral wording and likely responses without assuming motives. Flag claims that need evidence.

Documents: Summarize a document

COPY AND CUSTOMIZE

Summarize this source for [audience/purpose]. Return key points, numbers, decisions, obligations, caveats, and open questions. Use section/page pointers if available. Mark absent details “not specified.” Source: [paste].

Documents: Extract actions

COPY AND CUSTOMIZE

From these notes, list action, named owner, due date, supporting evidence, status, and open question. Do not infer owner or deadline; mark missing information. Notes: [paste].

Learning: Explain a concept

COPY AND CUSTOMIZE

Explain [concept] to a [level] learner. Give a definition, analogy, worked example, common misconception, and three questions. Wait for my attempt before revealing answers.

Learning: Flashcards from notes

COPY AND CUSTOMIZE

Using only these notes, create [number] flashcards with one core idea per card. Put answers separately. Label anything not supported by the notes as “verify with course source.” Notes: [paste].

Learning: Practice quiz

COPY AND CUSTOMIZE

Quiz me on [topic] at [level], one question at a time. Include recall, explanation, comparison, and application. Wait for my answer, provide feedback, and revisit weak topics. Source boundaries: [notes/textbook].

Career: CV gap analysis

COPY AND CUSTOMIZE

Compare my sanitized CV to this job description. Map each requirement to evidence, gap, and next action. Improve wording only using true supplied facts. Do not invent metrics, credentials, employers, or experience. CV: [paste]. Job: [paste].

Career: Mock interview

COPY AND CUSTOMIZE

Act as an interviewer for [role]. Ask one question at a time based on this job description: [paste]. Evaluate my answer for relevance, evidence, clarity, and honesty. Suggest a better structure using only my real experience.

Research: Research outline

COPY AND CUSTOMIZE

Create a research outline for [question]. Identify subquestions, strongest primary source types, competing explanations, date limits, and what evidence would change the conclusion. Do not fabricate sources.

Research: Evidence audit

COPY AND CUSTOMIZE

Review these claims and sources. For each claim, quote the relevant supporting passage or state that no support was found. Note source date, context, contradictions, and what remains uncertain. Claims/sources: [paste].

Business: Customer interview

COPY AND CUSTOMIZE

Write 8 neutral interview questions about how [customer group] currently solves [problem], how often it occurs, what it costs, what they tried, and what they would change. Avoid leading questions and requests for compliments.

Business: Business idea test

COPY AND CUSTOMIZE

List the riskiest assumptions behind [idea]. For each, propose a cheap test, evidence to collect, pass/fail signal, likely reasons not to buy, and next action. Do not claim demand or guaranteed revenue.

Business: Proposal outline

COPY AND CUSTOMIZE

Outline a proposal for [client/problem]. Include objective, scope, deliverables, assumptions, milestones, exclusions, risks, acceptance criteria, and questions to resolve. Do not invent pricing, credentials, or legal terms.

Customer support: FAQ from policy

COPY AND CUSTOMIZE

Use only this approved policy to draft customer questions and answers. Include steps and when to contact a human. Mark missing facts “owner confirmation required.” Flag billing, privacy, safety, refund, and legal escalations. Policy: [paste].

Marketing: Content calendar

COPY AND CUSTOMIZE

Plan [period] of content for [audience/topic/platform]. For each item give audience problem, hook, useful point, format, draft, CTA, and claims/assets to verify. Do not invent metrics, testimonials, endorsements, or scarcity.

Marketing: Repurpose content

COPY AND CUSTOMIZE

Turn this original material into [formats]. Keep facts and commitments consistent while adapting length and voice. List claims that need rechecking and indicate any content that would feel misleading out of context. Source: [paste].

Design: Design brief

COPY AND CUSTOMIZE

Create a brief for [asset]. Audience: [audience]. Goal: [goal]. Size/platform: [dimensions]. Exact required text: [copy]. Brand style: [details]. Return hierarchy, layout, image direction, contrast checks, and export checklist. Never invent contact details or endorsements.

Presentations: Slide outline

COPY AND CUSTOMIZE

Create a [duration]-minute presentation for [audience] about [topic]. Each slide needs a point-stating headline, evidence required, one suggested visual, and speaker note. Do not invent statistics. End with decision/next steps.

Data: Formula helper

COPY AND CUSTOMIZE

I use [Excel/Sheets]. Goal: [task]. Columns/types: [details]. Example rows: [sample]. Suggest a formula, explain it, and give three test cases with expected outputs, including blanks and edge cases. State locale assumptions.

Data: Data-cleaning plan

COPY AND CUSTOMIZE

Review these sanitized column names and sample rows. Propose rules for blanks, duplicates, dates, inconsistent labels, and outliers. Do not overwrite original data. Give before/after examples and validation tests.

Technical: Debug a problem

COPY AND CUSTOMIZE

Expected: [x]. Actual: [y]. Error: [message]. Environment/version: [details]. Minimal sanitized example: [code]. Rank likely

causes by evidence, suggest the smallest fix, and provide normal, boundary, and failure tests. Flag security/data-loss risks.

Automation: Automation plan

COPY AND CUSTOMIZE

Design a workflow for [task] across [apps]. Define trigger, input, transformation, conditions, duplicate prevention, permissions, logs, failure alerts, limits to verify, owner, and manual fallback. Do not ask for credentials.

Operations: SOP

COPY AND CUSTOMIZE

Turn these confirmed notes into an SOP for [audience]. Include purpose, roles, prerequisites, numbered steps, quality checks, exceptions/escalation, records, owner, version, and review date. Mark gaps “owner confirmation required.”

Decision support: Compare options

COPY AND CUSTOMIZE

Compare [options] against [criteria]. Show evidence, costs to confirm, trade-offs, reversibility, risks, and information that would change the choice. Distinguish facts from assumptions; do not invent figures.

Household: Weekly meal/routine plan

COPY AND CUSTOMIZE

Plan [meals/routine] with people/needs [details], budget [amount/currency], time [hours], available resources [list], and hard restrictions [list]. Include prep time, consolidated list, low-effort alternatives, and items whose price/availability needs checking.

Risk review: Output quality audit

COPY AND CUSTOMIZE

Review this output against: factual accuracy, evidence, completeness, audience fit, privacy/rights, actionability, and constraints. Score each 1-5, quote evidence for low scores, identify critical failures that override the average, and propose specific fixes. Output: [paste].

Workplace: Weekly update

COPY AND CUSTOMIZE

Using these confirmed notes and figures, prepare a weekly update with outcome, progress vs plan, risks, decisions needed, next actions, and named owners. Separate measured facts from interpretation. Do not create metrics or infer commitments.

Small business: Customer response review

COPY AND CUSTOMIZE

Review these sanitized replies against the approved policy for correctness, empathy, clarity, promise risk, and escalation. Cite the sentence that needs revision and provide a safer draft. Policy: [paste].

Planning: Risk register

COPY AND CUSTOMIZE

For [project], create a risk register with risk, cause, impact, likelihood (clearly marked as estimated), early warning sign, mitigation, contingency, owner, and review date. Mark unknowns for the project owner.

Communication: Plain-language rewrite

COPY AND CUSTOMIZE

Rewrite this for [audience] at a clear reading level. Preserve all important numbers, caveats, and obligations. Then list any phrase whose meaning might have changed. Text: [paste].

Translation: Translate with context

COPY AND CUSTOMIZE

Translate from [language/locale] to [language/locale] for [audience]. Preserve names, dates, quantities, product terms, and commitments. List ambiguous expressions and alternative local wording. Text: [paste].

Project work: Project kickoff brief

COPY AND CUSTOMIZE

Turn these notes into purpose, outcome, scope, deliverables, milestones, dependencies, roles, risks, assumptions, success measures, and open questions. Do not invent owners, dates, or budget. Notes: [paste].

Privacy: Sanitization help

COPY AND CUSTOMIZE

Review this sample before sharing it with an AI tool. Identify personal, client, confidential, credential, or contractual information to remove or generalize. Suggest a minimally altered synthetic example that preserves the problem structure.

Follow-up: Make the next step explicit

COPY AND CUSTOMIZE

Review this plan. Identify the single most important next action, what must be true before it starts, who must approve it, how completion will be checked, and the fallback if it fails. Plan: [paste].

Meetings: Meeting agenda

COPY AND CUSTOMIZE

Build a [duration]-minute agenda for [meeting purpose]. Desired outcome: [decision/action]. Participants: [roles]. Background: [confirmed notes]. Allocate time to topics, identify required pre-reading, and end with decisions, owners, and next steps. Do not invent participant views or prior decisions.

Client work: Client handoff note

COPY AND CUSTOMIZE

Turn these sanitized project notes into a client handoff with objective, completed work, deliverables and locations, approved decisions, open questions, risks, named owners, dates explicitly supplied, and next steps. Separate confirmed facts from assumptions. Do not invent commitments or mark anything approved unless the notes say so. Notes: [paste].

7. Work and corporate use: safe, repeatable adoption

The minimum control framework

Control	Minimum practical standard	Evidence to keep
Approved use	Document which tools, account types, data classes, and use cases are allowed.	Short approved-use note and route for exceptions.
Data minimization	Send only the information needed. Use synthetic or sanitized samples wherever possible.	Data fields removed and why the remaining data is necessary.
Access and identity	Use organization-managed accounts when required. Review connected apps, permissions, and multi-factor authentication.	Account owner, approved connectors, permission scope.
Human accountability	Assign a named owner to review each consequential AI-assisted deliverable.	Reviewer, approval date, decision/action owner.
Verification	Check factual claims, calculations, citations, formulas, and generated code.	Test cases, source links, review results.
Recordkeeping	For important work, record tool/account type, source material, date, reviewer, and corrections where useful.	Minimal audit record consistent with policy.
Monitoring and fallback	Define errors, alerts, stop conditions, and manual recovery.	Known failure cases, alert path, rollback instructions.
Review cadence	Recheck tools and policies when features, terms, incidents, or requirements change.	Owner and next review date.

Never enter the following into an unapproved tool

- Passwords, access tokens, API keys, recovery codes, and authentication secrets.
- Payment card details, bank credentials, or account identifiers that are not necessary for the task.
- Customer identity records, employee performance files, confidential client material, or private legal communications.
- Protected health information or other regulated information unless the organization has explicitly approved the tool and workflow for it.
- Unreleased financial results, confidential business plans, private contracts, or any information your policy or agreement forbids you to share.
- Copyrighted or licensed material beyond what you are allowed to upload or reproduce.

> **SANITIZE, DO NOT MERELY DISGUISE**
>
> Replacing a name with “Customer A” may not be enough if the remaining details identify the person. Remove or generalize identifiers, rare details, direct quotes, account numbers, and unrelated context. When possible, create a synthetic example with the same data shape.

Privacy settings are product-specific

Consumer tools and work products may have different data-use, retention, admin, connected-app, and training controls. Settings can change and account type matters. Review the current official policy for the precise service and account you are using; do not assume that a choice in a personal account satisfies company or client obligations.

As examples of why checking matters: OpenAI documents controls for model improvement in ChatGPT consumer services; Anthropic documents conditions affecting consumer versus commercial products; and Google publishes

a separate privacy hub for generative AI in Google Workspace. Consult the links in the reference desk rather than relying on a general claim about all AI tools.

Human review: match the control to the impact

Impact level	Examples	Minimum review
Low	Brainstorming, personal checklist, rough outline.	Quick plausibility and privacy check.
Medium	Public social post, client email, noncritical report, internal guide.	Fact, tone, rights, source, and policy check by owner.
High	Contracts, hiring, financial reporting, customer refunds, legal/medical/safety advice, decisions affecting rights.	Qualified accountable human, authoritative sources, formal approval process. AI is support, not final authority.
Critical / safety-sensitive	Emergency response, critical infrastructure, irreversible transactions, safety controls.	Follow established expert procedures; do not depend on unvalidated AI output.

A responsible team pilot in five stages

1. Select one narrow, low-risk use case and a process owner.
2. Define allowed inputs, output requirements, an acceptance checklist, and what the AI must not decide.
3. Create a test set with normal cases, edge cases, missing data, contradictions, and prohibited requests.
4. Compare the AI-assisted process with the existing process on quality, time, rework, and incidents.
5. Roll out only if the evidence supports it; train users and define monitoring, escalation, rollback, and review dates.

8. Quality, safety, and troubleshooting

The seven-point output check

Check	Ask yourself	Evidence of a pass
Accuracy	Are names, dates, amounts, quotes, formulas, and product details right?	Compared against source data or a known calculation.
Source quality	Do the sources exist and support the exact claim?	Opened pages and relevant passages, not only snippets.
Completeness	Are exceptions, dependencies, caveats, or opposing evidence missing?	Checklist or source comparison completed.
Audience fit	Is the result understandable and appropriate for the user?	Correct level, length, format, tone, and vocabulary.
Privacy and rights	Did it expose sensitive data or misuse content/assets?	Data minimization and permissions checked.
Actionability	Can someone use the result without guessing the missing step?	Clear sequence, owner, deadline if supplied, and completion condition.
Constraints	Did it respect budget, scope, platform, time, policy, and prohibited actions?	Every hard constraint checked explicitly.

A 1-5 scoring rubric

Score	Meaning	Action
1 - Fail	Wrong, unsupported, unsafe, or unusable.	Do not use. Find root cause and regenerate or use another method.
2 - Weak	Major gaps; much human repair required.	Narrow task, add context/source, or use a better-suited tool.
3 - Usable with edits	Useful draft, but important improvements remain.	Fix gaps and verify facts before delivery.
4 - Strong	Complete and accurate for the stated purpose, with small edits.	Complete normal human sign-off.
5 - Ready for this use	Meets every requirement, evidence and privacy checks passed.	Use only within intended scope; keep final accountability human.

> **CRITICAL FAILURE OVERRIDES THE AVERAGE**
>
> A high average score does not cancel a fabricated citation, invented CV credential, unsupported promise, privacy leak, incorrect financial total, unsafe instruction, or missing legal/policy caveat. Stop and fix any critical failure before use.

Common failures and fixes

Symptom	Why it happens	Repair
Confident but wrong	The model generates plausible text, not guaranteed truth.	Ask for assumptions and sources; verify independently; remove unsupported claims.
Fake or irrelevant citation	A citation may be incorrect, stale, or unrelated.	Open the source and match it to the claim. If no support exists, delete or qualify the claim.
Generic advice	The context, audience, constraints, and example are missing.	Add a real scenario, inputs, budget/time limits, desired output, and acceptance test.

Symptom	Why it happens	Repair
Invented details	The prompt lets gaps be silently completed.	Say “mark unknown; do not infer” and require questions for material gaps.
Long or repetitive output	No length or priority was set.	Set a limit, ask for ranked points, and request removal of repetition.
Output ignores format	The format request is ambiguous or too complex.	Show a tiny example of the desired table/structure, then ask it to match.
The tool cannot access something	Feature, file, connection, or region is unsupported.	Confirm capability; use official documentation or change the workflow.
Automation fails quietly	No validation, alert, owner, or fallback was defined.	Add logs, duplicate checks, failure alerts, manual recovery, and a stop switch.
Formula works only on easy rows	Blanks, data types, duplicates, or locale were omitted.	Test normal, blank, duplicate, boundary, and error cases on a copy.
Answer is polished but not useful	Appearance is mistaken for completion.	Check against a real deliverable standard and ask what action can be completed now.

High-stakes boundaries

Do not rely on an AI output as the sole authority for diagnosis or treatment, legal advice, tax decisions, investment decisions, emergency response, critical infrastructure, safety-critical instructions, or consequential employment/housing/credit decisions. It may help organize questions, summarize documents you can lawfully share, or explain terminology. Use qualified professionals, authoritative evidence, and the required formal process.

Academic integrity, copyright, and truthful promotion

- Follow the rules of your school, employer, publisher, client, and platform. AI help does not make prohibited submission or disclosure acceptable.
- Do not fabricate sources, research data, customer reviews, testimonials, credentials, endorsements, or performance metrics.
- Check permissions for photos, music, fonts, brand assets, datasets, and text used in commercial work.
- Disclose affiliate, sponsorship, or other material relationships where required by the applicable rules and market.
- Keep the meaning of original source material intact when summarizing, rewriting, or translating.

9. Seven-day implementation plan

This plan avoids trying to change every workflow at once. The objective is to discover one repeatable improvement, prove that it is accurate enough, and document how to use it again.

Day	Action	Proof of completion
1. Choose	Pick one repetitive, low-risk task and write what “done well” means.	Task statement, baseline time, and acceptance checklist.
2. Capture	Write down the current inputs, steps, exceptions, and output.	A short process note and sanitized sample.
3. Prompt	Run the task with the prompt formula and save the best prompt.	Reusable prompt with context, constraints, format, and acceptance test.
4. Test	Try normal, incomplete, edge, and contradictory inputs.	List of results, errors, fixes, and any case that needs a human.
5. Compare	Compare time and quality against the old method.	Before/after times, corrections required, and quality scores.
6. Document	Write a short checklist/SOP and define the human review.	Owner, steps, source of truth, approval, fallback.
7. Decide	Continue, revise, or stop.	Decision based on evidence; next review date if continuing.

Measure whether AI is actually helping

Use a small before/after test rather than relying on a generic promise about productivity. For a task, record the old time, AI-assisted time including review, corrections required, and critical errors. For repeated tasks, test enough examples to see whether one good result was a lucky exception.

Measure	Simple method	What to watch
Time saved	Baseline minutes - assisted minutes, including review.	Negative time savings are useful evidence too.
Rework	Count corrections or extra clarification rounds.	A fast first draft can be costly if it creates more repair work.
Accuracy	Check against known ground truth or authoritative source.	Critical errors must be tracked separately from average score.
Completion rate	Share of tasks accepted after normal review.	Define acceptance before testing to avoid moving the goalposts.
Cost	Subscription, credits, setup, maintenance, reviewer time.	Include hidden plan limits and workflow-switching costs.
User/customer outcome	Measure a meaningful result where appropriate.	Do not attribute every change to AI without supporting evidence.

A simple time-value calculator

For a repeated task, estimate the practical value only after testing:

Monthly Net Time Value

Monthly net minutes = (baseline minutes per task - AI-assisted minutes per task, including review) x number of tasks per month. Convert to hours by dividing by 60. Then weigh saved time against tool cost, setup/maintenance, quality risk, and any added review burden.

Example using hypothetical numbers: a task takes 18 minutes manually and 12 minutes with AI including review. At 40 tasks per month, the net difference is 240 minutes, or 4 hours. This is not a forecast for all users; it is a calculation the user should make from observed results.

When not to automate

- The task is too rare to justify setup and maintenance.
- The process is not yet stable or no one can explain the correct manual result.
- Errors would be serious and no appropriate review, recovery, or approval exists.
- The data is too sensitive for the available tool or account.
- The target app, plan, API, or permissions cannot support the workflow reliably.
- The tool creates more checking, copying, and context-switching than it removes.

Build a small personal prompt library

Field	What to save
Prompt name	Short title that describes the job.
Use case	When to use it; when not to use it.
Required inputs	Fields or source files needed; sanitization notes.
Prompt version	Current prompt and date last tested.
Known limitations	Tasks it does not handle reliably; facts requiring review.
Acceptance checklist	The conditions the output must meet before use.
Example	A sanitized input and a strong output example, if safe and permitted.

10. Reusable templates for real work

A. One-page project brief

Field	Fill this in
Purpose	Why are we doing this? What problem is it meant to solve?
Outcome	What observable result counts as success?
Audience/customer	Who will use or benefit from the output?
Scope	What is included and explicitly excluded?
Inputs and sources	What information is approved and where is the source of truth?
Constraints	Deadline, budget, format, tools, policy, accessibility, locale.
Deliverables	What will be handed over, in which format?
Risks and dependencies	What could block the work or make the result inaccurate?
Owner and approvals	Who does the work, who reviews it, who approves it?
Acceptance criteria	What must be true before the work is considered complete?

B. Output acceptance checklist

- Does it answer the actual question or complete the intended task?
- Can every important fact, amount, date, source, and promise be verified?
- Are assumptions and unknowns marked rather than hidden?
- Is the output complete for the audience and format?
- Does it respect privacy, permissions, copyright, and policy?
- Are the next steps, owner, deadline, and approval explicit where known?
- Have critical failure cases been considered and tested?
- Is the final version saved in the approved location with a clear name/version?

C. Decision memo template

Decision to make: [question]

Recommendation: [option, only after evidence review]

What is known: [verified facts and sources]

What remains uncertain: [assumptions and missing data]

Options considered: [option A/B/C]

Trade-offs: [cost, time, risk, reversibility, opportunity cost]

Conditions that would change the recommendation: [evidence]

Decision owner / review date: [name/role and date]

D. Simple risk register

Risk	Early warning	Prevention / mitigation	Fallback	Owner
Wrong source or outdated fact	Official page date is old or source does not match claim.	Open primary source; record current version/date.	Withdraw or correct affected output.	[role]

Risk	Early warning	Prevention / mitigation	Fallback	Owner
Private data exposure	Prompt includes identifiable records or credentials.	Minimize/sanitize; use approved accounts.	Follow incident process and notify required owner.	[role]
Automation duplicates	Repeated trigger creates multiple records/actions.	Stable key, duplicate check, test data.	Pause workflow; reconcile affected records.	[role]
Tool limit reached	Run volume approaches plan limit.	Check current allowance and alert thresholds.	Manual process or approved alternative.	[role]
AI output breaks policy	Answer makes unapproved commitment.	Source-grounded prompt and human review.	Correct response and notify owner if needed.	[role]

E. A useful meeting-notes template

Meeting purpose: [purpose]

Date/participants: [details permitted to share]

Decisions confirmed: [decision + evidence]

Actions: [task | owner | due date | status]

Open questions: [question | owner to resolve if assigned]

Risks/dependencies: [risk | impact | next check]

Next meeting/review: [date or “not scheduled”]

F. Change log for an AI-assisted process

Version/date	Change	Reason/evidence	Approved by	Next review
v1.0 / [date]	Initial workflow and acceptance test.	Baseline and pilot results.	[owner]	[date]
v1.1 / [date]	Updated prompt or review step.	Recurring error or policy change.	[owner]	[date]

11. Quick reference glossary

Term	Plain-language meaning
AI assistant	A tool that responds to instructions and supports text, files, analysis, planning, or other enabled tasks.
Prompt	The instruction and context given to the assistant.
Hallucination	A plausible-sounding output that is not supported by facts or sources.
Grounding	Tying an answer to supplied documents, verified data, or reliable sources.
Primary source	Original evidence such as official records, source data, regulations, or original research.
Acceptance criteria	Conditions that must be met before a deliverable is accepted.
Human-in-the-loop	A person checks or approves output before a consequential action.
Data minimization	Sharing only the information necessary for a task.
Free tier	A no-cost product level that may have feature, usage, export, or support limits.
Automation	Software steps that move data or take actions based on triggers and rules.
SOP	Standard operating procedure: documented steps for carrying out a recurring process.
Prompt injection	Instructions inside untrusted content that try to change the intended behavior or reveal information.
Model / version	The particular AI system or build used; behavior and capabilities can differ by version.
Context window	The amount of information a model can consider within a given interaction; practical limits vary.
Synthetic data	Made-up data designed to resemble the structure of real data without copying real personal records.
Reversibility	How easily a choice can be changed or undone if the result is wrong.
Source of truth	The approved record or document that controls when versions disagree.
Edge case	An unusual, boundary, incomplete, or unexpected input that may break a simple workflow.

12. Official reference desk

These links are provided for direct checking, not as permanent statements that a feature is available to every account. Where a product's terms or plan details matter, record the date you reviewed the page and the exact account/plan type. Reference links checked for this edition on 15 October 2026. Product pages and service terms may change after publication.

Official reference	Open page	What to verify
ChatGPT FAQ	ChatGPT FAQ	Official overview of capabilities and access.
ChatGPT Free Tier FAQ	ChatGPT Free Tier FAQ	Current free-tier limitations and feature availability.
OpenAI data use for consumer services	OpenAI data use for consumer services	Consumer services data-use choices and distinctions from business offerings.
ChatGPT data controls	ChatGPT data controls	Controls for model improvement, history, exports, and related settings; exact controls depend on account and workspace.
Gemini Apps limits	Gemini Apps limits	Usage limits and feature availability vary by plan, account, and region.
Gemini Apps Privacy Hub	Gemini Apps Privacy Hub	How personal Gemini Apps handle prompts, uploads, connected apps, activity settings, and privacy.
Google Workspace generative AI privacy hub	Google Workspace generative AI privacy hub	Privacy information for Gemini in Workspace and related Google offerings.
Claude plan choices	Claude plan choices	Current plan descriptions and usage capacity.
Anthropic consumer data training FAQ	Anthropic consumer data training FAQ	Consumer product data-use conditions.
Perplexity plan guidance	Perplexity plan guidance	Official plan, product, citation, and data-use guidance; verify the current product/account type.
NotebookLM Help Center	NotebookLM Help Center	Official help center for current source types, features, and limits.
Canva pricing and AI allowance	Canva pricing and AI allowance	Plan features and AI allowance; verify the exact usage conditions before relying on an allowance.
Adobe Express Free plan	Adobe Express Free plan	Free plan features and limitations.
Gamma pricing	Gamma pricing	Creation credits, output limits, branding, and export options.
Zapier Free plan	Zapier Free plan	Current published free-plan allowance and supported workflow shape.
Zapier task limits	Zapier task limits	Task counting and limits.
Make pricing	Make pricing	Current plan/credit conditions.
GitHub Copilot plans	GitHub Copilot plans	Current code-assistant plans and limits.
Otter pricing	Otter pricing	Current transcription and plan limits.

Official reference	Open page	What to verify
Unsplash license	Unsplash license	Photo license terms; assess each asset/context.
FTC endorsement guidance	FTC endorsement guidance	US guidance on endorsements and material connections; confirm applicable rules in your market.

Keeping your AI practice current

AI products change quickly. Treat the official reference desk as a launch point, not a permanent promise about price, availability, privacy, or feature access. Before building a recurring task around a product, confirm the exact plan, account type, region, export options, data controls, and any limits that could interrupt your workflow.

A monthly 15-minute reset

- Choose the two or three workflows you actually use and check whether they still save time after review and correction.
- Recheck any tool or account that handles confidential, customer, student, employee, financial, or regulated information.
- Update prompts when a recurring error appears; record the change and test it on the same sample case.
- Remove tools and automations nobody uses, and keep a manual fallback for anything important.
- Review official plan, privacy, and licensing pages before paying, expanding access, or publishing generated work.

> **THE STANDARD TO KEEP**
>
> A good AI workflow is not the one that produces the most impressive first answer. It is the one that produces a fit-for-purpose result, survives verification, protects the information involved, and can be repeated reliably.